

What They Called Recovery

KDP Final Publication Preparation Roadmap

Kindle-first publication workflow | Version 1.0 | 14 August 2026

1. Purpose and governing objective

This roadmap governs all remaining editorial and production work on What They Called Recovery after completion of the Phase 7 cold-read audit. The publication target is Amazon Kindle Direct Publishing (KDP), initially as a reflowable Kindle ebook. The workflow is deliberately narrow: the story, canon, chronology, character arcs and structural decisions are considered locked unless a later proof exposes an actual error.

The objective is to produce a copy-edited, proofed, KDP-ready reflowable edition that is validated in Kindle Previewer and KDP's online preview environment, with a final ebook cover, metadata and publication files ready for submission.

2. Publication scope

- Primary release target: Amazon Kindle Direct Publishing (KDP), Kindle ebook.
- Edition type: reflowable text-led ebook, suitable for Kindle e-readers, Kindle apps, phones and tablets.
- Canonical story reference during production: the 46 Phase 7-complete chapter PDFs.
- Production source to be created: one clean master DOCX assembled from the canonical chapters and verified against those PDFs.
- Kindle production project: Kindle Create project (KCB plus related project resources).
- Primary upload artifact: KPF exported from Kindle Create. A clean DOCX and, where practical, an EPUB export are retained as future-proof source artifacts.
- Paperback/hardcover production is out of scope. It may be started later under a separate print-production roadmap.

3. KDP-specific production constraints

Amazon KDP currently accepts several ebook manuscript formats, including DOC/DOCX, EPUB and KPF. Kindle Create converts DOC/DOCX into a reflowable ebook and exports a KPF for KDP submission. Kindle Previewer supports reflowable files and allows inspection across representative Kindle e-reader, phone and tablet views. The final KDP upload also provides an online preview step.

- Do not use fixed PDF page geometry as the Kindle reading model. Reader-controlled font size, screen size and line wrapping must be allowed to reflow naturally.
- Chapter titles must be semantically identifiable so Kindle Create can build reliable navigation and table-of-contents entries.
- Do not use manual spaces, repeated blank lines, text boxes or page-position tricks to create layout.

- Scene breaks must survive reflow and remain visually unambiguous at different text sizes.
- Paragraph indents, italics/emphasis, chapter breaks and dialogue spacing must be represented structurally, not by fixed visual positioning.
- The cover supplied to KDP is a separate marketing-cover file. KDP currently recommends a portrait ebook cover around 2,560 x 1,600 pixels in RGB, with JPEG preferred.

4. Change-control rules

- No developmental rewriting during this workflow.
- No new scenes, plot beats, character motivations, backstory, chronology changes or stylistic re-voicing unless an actual contradiction or reader-blocking error is discovered.
- Copy-edit changes must be local and defensible: grammar, punctuation, syntax, accidental repetition, consistency, malformed wording or genuine sentence-level ambiguity.
- Every substantive wording change is logged by chapter and reason.
- Formatting changes are production changes only and must not alter story meaning.
- The Phase 7 PDFs remain the regression reference when checking that conversion and copy-editing have not silently changed content.

5. Phase structure

Phase 0 — Publication lock and baseline

- Freeze the Phase 7-complete manuscript as the publication baseline.
- Verify the 46 canonical chapter PDFs, chapter order and integrity.
- Record the publication target as Kindle-first KDP reflowable ebook.
- Create this roadmap, a publication status file and a new KDP working manifest.
- Preserve the Phase 7 source package as a read-only rollback point.

PASS GATE: A verified, immutable Phase 7 baseline exists and the KDP workflow control files are present.

Phase 1 — Assemble the reflowable master source

- Extract and assemble the 46 canonical chapters into one master DOCX in exact chapter order.
- Preserve chapter titles, paragraph boundaries, dialogue separation, scene breaks and meaningful emphasis.
- Remove PDF-only page artifacts such as page-number dependencies, forced line endings and layout noise.
- Do not copy-edit during assembly except to fix clear extraction damage.
- Run chapter-by-chapter normalized-text comparison against the canonical PDFs and investigate every mismatch.
- Create semantic Heading 1 chapter titles and true page breaks before each chapter.

PASS GATE: The master DOCX contains all 46 chapters in order, no chapter is missing or duplicated, and all text differences from the canonical PDFs are explained and logged.

Phase 2 — Final copy-edit and style sheet

- Create and lock a style sheet covering character/place names, capitalization, hyphenation, numerals, time expressions, recurring technical terms, dialogue punctuation, ellipses/dashes and preferred spellings.
- Copy-edit Chapters 1–46 sequentially using the style sheet.
- Correct grammar, punctuation, accidental repetition, malformed sentences, local ambiguity and inconsistent usage.
- Do not polish merely because an alternative sentence is possible.
- Log each wording change with chapter, original text, replacement and reason.

PASS GATE: All chapters have completed copy-edit; no unresolved copy-edit query remains; the style sheet is complete and internally consistent.

Phase 3 — Post-copy-edit regression verification

- Compare the copy-edited DOCX against the Phase 7 canonical PDFs and the copy-edit log.
- Re-run targeted continuity searches for dates, names, ages, recurring objects and previously corrected problem areas.
- Cold-read chapter transitions for any edit-introduced discontinuity.
- Confirm that no copy-edit changed plot, character knowledge, chronology or reveal order.

PASS GATE: Every text change is accounted for and no new Critical or High continuity defect exists.

Phase 4 — Kindle-ready document preparation

- Prepare front matter: title page, copyright page and any other approved opening material.
- Prepare back matter only if deliberately approved (for example author note, acknowledgements or other books).
- Normalize body styles for reflow: first-line indents, paragraph spacing, italics, scene breaks and chapter starts.
- Remove manual layout hacks, hard tabs, repeated spaces, unnecessary blank paragraphs and fixed-page assumptions.
- Ensure chapter headings are correctly detected for Kindle navigation and TOC generation.
- Create a clean publication DOCX separate from the editorial working DOCX.

PASS GATE: The publication DOCX is structurally clean, reflow-safe and ready to import into Kindle Create without relying on fixed-page formatting.

Phase 5 — Kindle Create build

- Import the publication DOCX into Kindle Create as a reflowable project.
- Confirm all 46 chapter titles and navigation entries.
- Generate and inspect the Kindle Interactive TOC and any visible contents page we choose to include.
- Apply one restrained Kindle Create theme consistently.
- Check chapter openings, paragraph indentation, italics, scene breaks and front/back matter.
- Save and archive the editable KCB project and all related resources.
- Export the publication KPF.

PASS GATE: The KCB project reopens cleanly, all navigation is correct, and the exported KPF contains the complete book.

Phase 6 — Kindle Previewer quality assurance

- Open the KPF (and optionally the DOCX/EPUB comparison source) in Kindle Previewer.
- Inspect representative Kindle e-reader, phone and tablet views.
- Test multiple font sizes and orientations where available.
- Check chapter navigation, TOC links, scene breaks, orphaned headings, blank pages, paragraph indents, italics and unusual spacing.
- Read every chapter at least once in the rendered Kindle environment, focusing on conversion defects rather than prose rewriting.
- Record and repair only reproducible Kindle-format defects, then re-export and re-preview.

PASS GATE: No material formatting/navigation defect remains in Kindle Previewer at the supported device classes.

Phase 7 — Cover and Amazon metadata package

- Choose/finalize the Kindle ebook cover using KDP ebook-cover specifications and ensure title/author text exactly matches listing metadata.
- Prepare final title, subtitle if any, author/pen name, description, rights declaration, primary marketplace and language.
- Prepare discoverability inputs: relevant categories and keyword phrases within KDP rules.
- Decide pricing, royalty option, territories and whether to enroll in KDP Select/Kindle Unlimited.
- Record all publication metadata in a single controlled metadata sheet before entering it into KDP.

PASS GATE: Cover and metadata are internally consistent, final, rights-safe and ready for direct entry into KDP.

Phase 8 — KDP upload and online preview gate

- Create or open the KDP Kindle ebook title entry.
- Enter the locked metadata exactly as approved.
- Upload the final KPF and marketing cover.
- Use KDP's online previewer for the final platform-side check.
- Verify the first pages, random middle chapters, final chapters, navigation and cover/listing consistency.
- Resolve any KDP validation warnings that indicate real quality defects.
- Do not press Publish until the final sign-off checklist is complete.

PASS GATE: KDP accepts the files, the online preview is clean, and the publication checklist is signed off.

Phase 9 — Release archive and post-publication control

- Archive the final publication DOCX, KCB project, KPF, cover source/export, metadata sheet, style sheet, copy-edit log and final manifest.
- Create checksums for the exact release artifacts.
- After publication, verify the live Amazon detail page and a delivered Kindle sample/copy where available.

- Any later correction becomes a separately logged post-publication patch; do not silently overwrite the release archive.

PASS GATE: A reproducible release archive exists and the live Kindle edition matches the approved publication package.

6. Severity and decision rules

- Critical: prevents publication, corrupts content, changes story meaning, breaks navigation broadly, or produces materially unreadable Kindle output. Must fix.
- High: significant reader-facing error, continuity regression, missing/duplicated content, major formatting or metadata problem. Must fix before moving forward.
- Medium: localized but real error or inconsistency. Fix during the current phase unless doing so creates disproportionate risk.
- Low: optional preference, micro-style alternative or cosmetic difference without reader impact. Do not change automatically; record only if useful.

7. Definition of done

- The complete 46-chapter manuscript exists as a verified reflowable master source.
- Final copy-edit is complete and every substantive wording change is logged.
- No Critical or High continuity or regression issue remains.
- The Kindle Create project is complete and archived.
- The KPF passes Kindle Previewer inspection across Kindle e-reader, phone and tablet views.
- Front matter, navigation, chapter structure and scene breaks behave correctly in reflow.
- The ebook cover and Amazon metadata are final and mutually consistent.
- The KDP online preview is clean and all platform warnings have been assessed.
- A final release archive exists with checksums and all source/publication artifacts required for future updates.

8. Stopping rule

When the definition of done is satisfied and the Kindle edition has passed final KDP preview/sign-off, editorial work stops. Further prose changes require a separately justified post-publication correction or a new edition objective. The existence of an alternative wording is not, by itself, a reason to reopen the manuscript.

9. Current starting state

- Phase 7 cold-read audit: complete and passed.
- Canonical manuscript: 46 chapter PDFs in the Phase 7 complete source tree.
- Current publication target: Kindle-first Amazon KDP reflowable ebook.
- Current next executable phase: Phase 0 publication lock and baseline, immediately followed by Phase 1 assembly of the single reflowable master DOCX.
- Final author/pen-name metadata, pricing, categories, keywords, KDP Select choice and final cover selection remain publication-stage decisions and do not block manuscript-source preparation.

10. Official KDP references used for this roadmap

- Amazon KDP Help — What file formats are supported for eBook manuscripts?
- Amazon KDP Help — Prepare Reflowable and Print Books with Kindle Create.
- Amazon KDP Help — eBook Manuscript Formatting Guide.
- Amazon KDP Help — Kindle Previewer.
- Amazon KDP Help — Guide to Kindle Content Quality.
- Amazon KDP Help — What criteria does my eBook's cover image need to meet?

Requirements verified against Amazon KDP Help on 14 August 2026. Platform requirements should be rechecked immediately before the KDP upload phase.